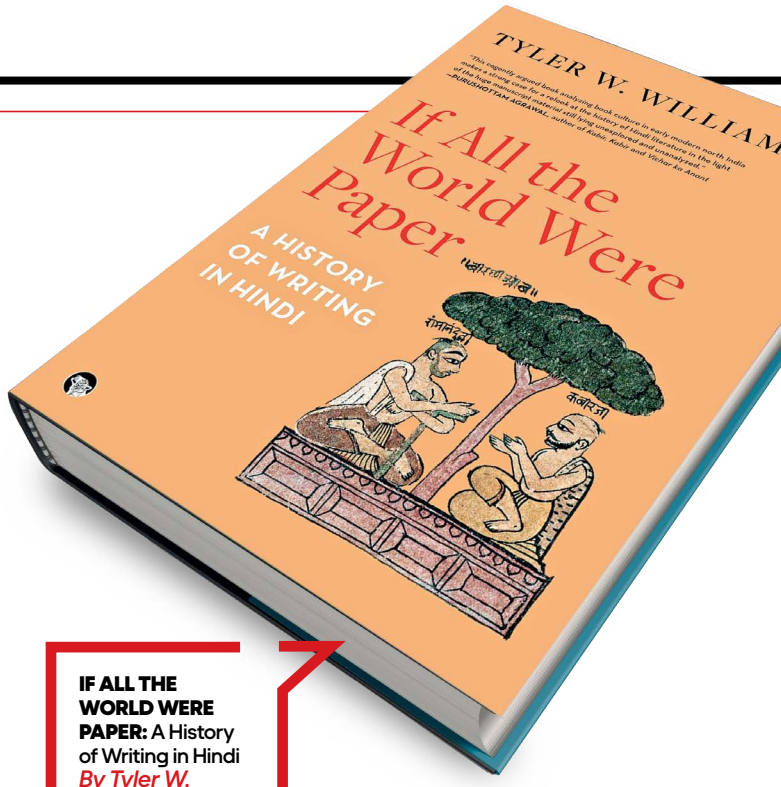
BOOKS ▼

THE **ROOTS** OF HINDI

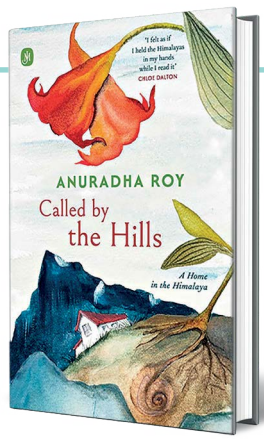
Using forgotten manuscripts from little-known archives, Tyler W. Williams reveals Hindi's socially complex literary past



IF ALL THE WORLD WERE PAPER: A History of Writing in Hindi
By Tyler W. Williams
SPEAKING TIGER
₹599; 352 pages

The matter of 'Hindi' is an ideological minefield. Research in Hindi is, therefore, a high-risk operation. Tripwires abound, and one is constantly required to utter the crucial passwords—*rashtrabhasha*, Sanskrit-putri, etc.—to earn safe passage. Apart from the familiar physical and institutional difficulties, there is the sense that any deviation from well-trodden discursive paths will end badly. It is much safer to be boring, and many are.

Tyler W. Williams's monograph—*If All the World Were Paper: A History of Writing in Hindi*—relies upon an



CALLED BY THE HILLS
By Anuradha Roy
HACHETTE/ JOHN MURRAY INDIA
₹999; 184 pages

WITH FAMILIAR HIMALAYAN ICONOGRAPHY **AND AMAZING TURNS OF PHRASE, THE AUTHOR** TRANSFORMS THE MUNDANE INTO THE MAGICAL

BOOKS ▼

Magic Mountains

ANURADHA ROY pens a moving memoir about creating an idyllic life in the hills

Several years ago, Anuradha Roy, and R, who appears frequently in the book, escaped the capitally punished gas chamber and set up their publishing venture in quaint Ranikhet. Staffed by adopted strays, run on patchy electric supplies and internet, Permanent Black has since become one of the most sought-after imprint in the country.

As I unboxed my copy of Anuradha's new book, *Called by the Hills*, I couldn't help remarking that being a publisher-author sure has its perks, for, even before you get to the writing, you admire the perfect binding, the plum-coloured gilding on the page edges, picture postcards and bookmarks, and the author's own watercolours.

Called by the Hills, but do the hills really call? Haven't they had enough of people coming to them after having ruined their own city's AQI, one wonders. For someone who lives in the Himalaya and often deals with wannabe *pahadis*, the storyline seemed familiar and, I must admit, a tad clichéd. But as you read along, you realise that the hills do not call often, but for whoever presses the accept button, and agrees to live life at nature's pace—a pace of peace, patience and prayer—the rewards are immeasurable. This book, by weaving the personal into the historic, introduces us to some of those pleasures with a turn of phrase that amazes. With familiar Himalayan characters, trees, plants and flowers flitting in and out of the book, the author transforms the mundane into the magical. This is a one-shot read, if you really love your mountains. ■

—Lokesh Ohri